

DECODED EXPLAINED

7 August 2026

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Handloom — weaving India's heritage into global growth

The making of a developed nation is not defined by technology alone. It is shaped by the ability to transform enduring strengths into engines of future growth. As India advances towards **Viksit Bharat 2047**, it is investing in frontier technologies, strengthening manufacturing and building globally competitive industries.

Yet, one of India's greatest strengths has been with India all along – its handloom tradition. On August 7, as India marks the 12th National Handloom Day, it is time to view handloom as a strategic sector for a world that values sustainability, authenticity and resilient supply chains.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 is built on prosperity, self-reliance, inclusivity and cultural confidence. Handloom embodies this vision by bringing together heritage and innovation, while driving women-led development, rural entrepreneurship, livelihoods and global competitiveness.

Threads of India's legacy

Every handwoven fabric reflects the courage to preserve tradition, the patience to perfect every thread, the integrity of honest craftsmanship and the wisdom passed down through generations. That is why handloom is not merely a craft, but one of India's greatest civilisational strengths. From the Indus Valley Civilisation, where cotton was first cultivated and woven, to the 18th century when Indian textiles dominated global trade, India set global benchmarks in textile excellence. Bengal's legendary muslin – so fine that a 25-metre length could pass through a ring – along with Banarasi silk, Kanchipuram weaves, Pochampally Ikat and countless regional traditions, earned India worldwide admiration.

Today, as the world turns towards authentic, sustainable and handcrafted products, India has a historic opportunity to reclaim that leadership.



Giriraj Singh

Union Minister
of Textiles,
Government of India

India's ancient
handloom
traditions can
transform
heritage into
a globally
competitive
creative
economy

India's next handloom revolution must export not just textiles, but also craftsmanship, heritage, innovation and trust, making every handwoven product an ambassador of Brand India.

Transformation through policy

Handloom is India's largest cottage industry, supporting the livelihoods of more than 35 lakh weavers and allied workers, nearly 72% of whom are women. Over the past decade, the Government has strengthened the sector through the **Raw Material Supply Scheme**, 797 handloom clusters, over 1.24 lakh improved looms, skill upgradation for nearly 97,000 artisans, and initiatives such as Producer Companies, GI tagged products, the Handloom Mark, India Handmade certification, Urban Haats and Design Resource Centres.

Today, 29 Weavers' Service Centres provide end to end support through training, upskilling, design development, raw material assistance and market linkages, while the 11 Indian Institutes of Handloom Technology are being strengthened to expand advanced training and develop niche, high-value handloom products. The forthcoming National Handloom and Handicraft Programme will accelerate this transformation by strengthening 1,800 clusters across more than 500 districts, benefiting 65 lakh weavers and artisans and establishing Handmade in India as a globally recognised brand.

Innovation has always been part of India's handloom journey. Mahatma Gandhi's Ambar Charkha made spinning easier, faster and more efficient, advancing the vision of self-reliance.

More recently, Assam's Maina Loom and the Chitrangan Handloom developed in Sivasagar have shown how better loom design can make weaving easier and more productive. The Centre of Excellence for Handloom Technology, established with the Indian Institutes of Technology, is developing lighter, stronger and easier to use looms that reduce physical effort

and improve productivity, including for persons with disabilities.

Under the Centre, the Handloom 4.0 initiative uses digital tools and Artificial Intelligence to monitor productivity, quality and maintenance, and is being piloted on 100 looms before expanding across the States.

Technology should empower the artisan, not replace the artisan. Platforms such as VisioNXT can help forecast demand, identify design trends, authenticate genuine handloom products and connect weavers directly with global markets. At the same time, product diversification into premium silk, natural fibres, sustainable fibres and innovative blends can create high-value products and unlock new markets.

Combined with better branding, value addition and direct market access, these innovations can significantly enhance weavers' incomes. The vision is to enable every weaver to earn a dignified and aspirational income, with the ambition of ₹50,000 per month in the years ahead.

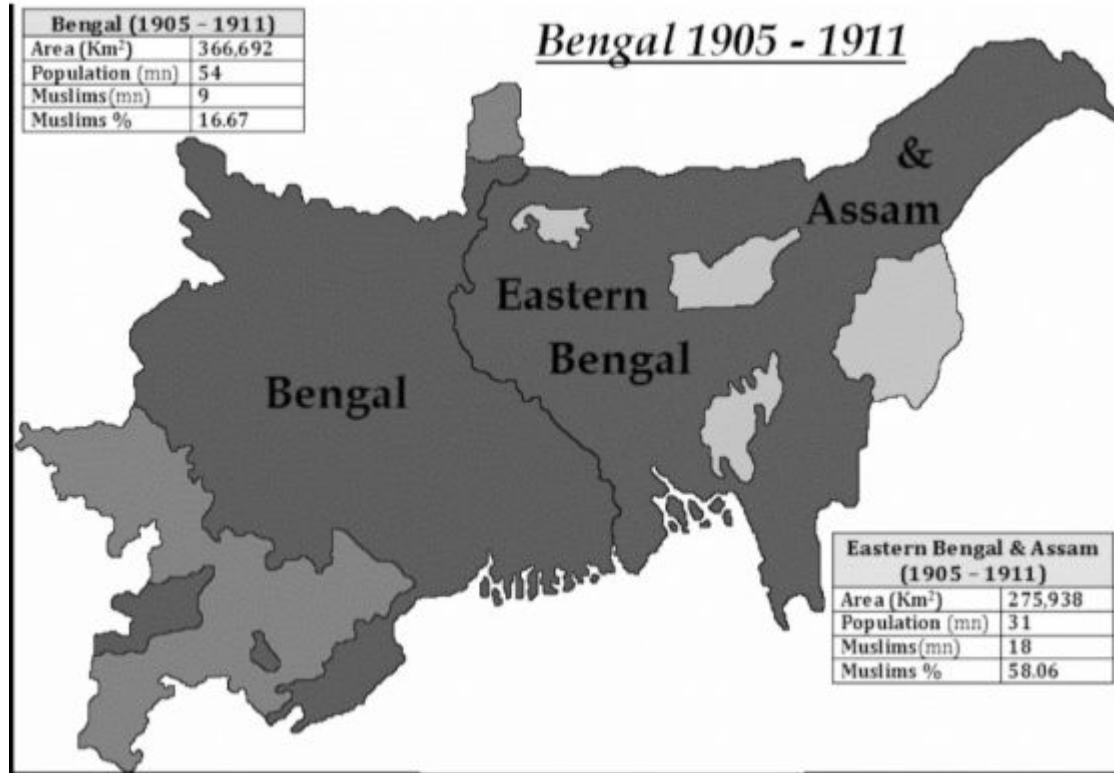
India's identity

India's weavers are not merely a workforce. They are entrepreneurs, innovators and creators of value. By enabling them to build brands, move up the value chain and reach global markets, handloom can be transformed into one of India's most dynamic creative industries. This is also a call to India's youth to bring together heritage and technology, creativity and enterprise, to shape the next chapter of handloom.

On this National Handloom Day, let us celebrate India's weavers not only as custodians of our heritage, but also as architects of India's progress. Every handloom product we buy and wear strengthens a weaver's livelihood, preserves a timeless tradition and carries India's story to the world.

The views expressed are personal

1. **Handloom weaving India's heritage into global growth - by Giriraj Singh (Union minister of textiles)**
 - **National handloom day - August 7 ,since 2015**
 - **Why this day - Lord Curzon partitioned Bengal in 1905 , officially for "administrative convenience," really to split the region along Hindu-Muslim lines and weaken the nationalist movement centred there. In response, the Swadeshi Movement was formally launched at the Calcutta Town Hall on 7 August 1905, calling for a boycott of British goods**



- The partition divided the province into two parts: Muslim-majority Eastern Bengal and Assam, and Hindu-majority Western Bengal (which included Bihar and Odisha). The partition divided the province into two parts: Muslim-majority Eastern Bengal and Assam, and Hindu-majority Western Bengal (which included Bihar and Odisha).

Due to the unstoppable protests and rising revolutionary terrorism, the British were forced to **annul (reverse) the partition of Bengal in 1911**

Handloom Sector

- India's largest cottage industry (A **cottage industry** is a small-scale, decentralized manufacturing business operated out of a person's home rather than a purpose-built factory)
- 35+ lakh weavers and allied workers
- **72% of the workforce are women**

Schemes mentioned in the article

- The National Handloom Development Programme (NHDP) is the Ministry of Textiles' umbrella scheme funding the handloom sector end-to-end . Under it sit the Raw Material Supply Scheme, Producer Companies, GI tagging, Handloom Mark, India Handmade certification, Urban Haats, Design Resource Centres, Weavers' Service Centres, Indian Institutes of Handloom Technology, Centre of Excellence for Handloom Technology, Handloom 4.0, VisioNXT, and the National Handloom and Handicraft Programme , covering raw material, training, design, certification, markets, and technology.

PYQ 2023

Statement-I: 7th August is declared as the National Handloom Day.

Statement-II: It was in 1905 that the Swadeshi Movement was launched on the same day.

- (a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is the correct explanation for Statement-I
- (b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II is not the correct explanation for Statement-I
- (c) Statement-I is correct but Statement-II is incorrect
- (d) Statement-I is incorrect but Statement-II is correct

Govt. okays ₹23,371 cr. GOBARDhan scheme

The National Circular Bioenergy Scheme aspires to raise local production of CBG by tenfold, mobilise private investments on a large scale

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The Union cabinet approved the National Circular Bioenergy Scheme - GOBARDhan, provisioning ₹23,731-crore to catalyse the growth of compressed biogas (CBG).

The GOBARDhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) outlay, to be in place until FY2035-36 seeks to raise local compressed biogas production almost tenfold via assured offtake, administered pricing, capital subsidies, boosting pipeline infrastructure and easier access to finance, the Centre said.

The government emphasised the scheme would seek to impart a “strong and predictable framework” to fuel the up-tick of the CBG ecosystem.



Energy security: The compressed biogas plant at Brahmapuram currently processes about 50 tonne of biodegradable waste a day.

The programme would involve the use of agricultural residue, cattle dung, sugar industry waste such as press mud, municipal organic waste and other biomass to produce compressed biogas, which can be blended into CNG used in automobiles and also piped natural gas (PNG).

Three imperatives

Welcoming the government initiative, A.R. Shuk-

la, President of the Indian Biogas Association said the scheme addresses three imperatives – remunerative price, assured offtake and capital support – sought by the industry.

“This scheme delivers all three,” he said, adding, “moving from 300 operating plants towards 5,000 [plants] will create lakhs of rural jobs. Industry must respond with speed, quality and discipline.”

GOBARdhan Scheme

Full form: Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan

Objective

Launched in 2018 as part of the Biodegradable Waste Management component under Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen)

Scientific management of cattle and organic waste to produce biogas, Compressed Bio-Gas (CBG), bio-CNG, and organic fertiliser/bio-slurry

Also cuts chemical fertiliser use by promoting bio-slurry and organic manure, improving soil health

Nodal body for the original scheme: Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Ministry of Jal Shakti

On 6 August 2026, the Union Cabinet approved a much bigger version of this scheme , GOBARdhan, now formally the National Circular Bioenergy Scheme

- Now administered by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas , a shift from the original DDWS/Jal Shakti model
- Gives CBG producers assured stable pricing, capital assistance, pipeline connectivity and credit support
- Builds on earlier efforts like SATAT [Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation]

SATAT

- Launched on 1 October 2018 by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas
- Objective: get entrepreneurs to set up Compressed Bio-Gas (CBG) plants using farm residue, cattle dung, and municipal solid waste, then supply that CBG to fuel stations as automotive fuel

Growing your own food, time for leisure: what life is like in a blue zone

A blue zone, a concept introduced by journalist Dan Buettner, demographer Michel Poulain, and physician Gianni Pes, describes a region with high longevity. Ogimi, a village in Okinawa, Japan, is a lush landscape dotted with small farms where residents live with a strong sense of purpose

Meenakshi S.

The air is heavy, but the skies are clear on a July afternoon in Okinawa, Japan's southernmost and westernmost prefecture, a tropical paradise, a globally recognised 'blue zone', and home to some of the people who have lived the longest. It has been only a day or two since Typhoon Ravi churned its waters and toppled trees, but Okinawans believe typhoons are not merely inevitable, they are essential. "It cleanses our soul," says Hisami Takayama, 62, who has worked as a travel guide in the region for several years.

A blue zone, a concept introduced by journalist Dan Buettner, demographer Michel Poulain, and physician Gianni Pes, in essence, describes a region with high longevity. Santitas in Italy and Nicoya in Costa Rica are some of the other recognised blue zones.

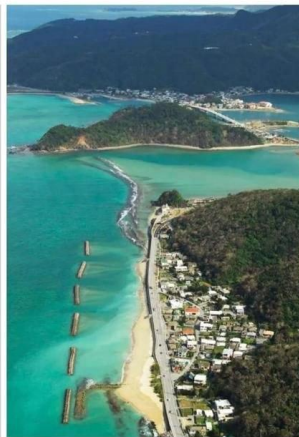
Perhaps the most remarkable thing about this island of longevity is that its nature and culture are so deeply intertwined that they are almost impossible to separate. The greatest living proof of this, is a village less than two hours from Naha city, along the coast overlooking Okinawa's brilliant blue and purple waters.

The residents of Ogimi are all about the spirit of *nankuru nai* or - the Okinawan belief that, in the end, everything will be alright and life should not be taken too seriously

One of us became familiar with through the acclaimed self-help book - while embracing a certain slowness unique to the region, starkly different from the bustling city life of Tokyo.

Prevention better than cure. What drives longevity here? Food, of course, is one of the biggest factors. Okinawans follow a basic rule: *hara hachi bu*, which means, eating until you are 80% full. They also believe that good health begins with the food they eat. Okinawans place greater emphasis on prevention than treating illness after it occurs - a philosophy influenced by Chinese culture, which believes that food and medicine come from the same source.

Morio Taira, 91, eats about three meals a day - meat, lots of vegetables, and fruits, whether they are bitter, sour, or sweet. An Ogimi table makes the best use of whatever is grown in the village during that particular season. Their diet is especially rich in green and yellow vegetables, including bitter gourd, mugwort, and landlamb. A local specialty fruit, shibusha kenon, is used abundantly; it is believed to be high in indole-3-carbinol, a compound that may support cognitive function and help manage glucose levels, according to some studies. They also consume protein-rich tofu from the island. Purple sweet potato, which is rich



Blue waters: Ogimi is a lush landscape dotted with small farms. (AP/Wide World)



A typical meal, generally built around a bowl of rice and paired with soup. (AP/Wide World)

in antioxidants, is a staple ingredient in many of their dishes. Traditional Okinawan cuisine relies heavily on *dashu*, a broth that forms the base of many dishes and is rich in *umami* (the savory taste), a term that any food lover associates with Japanese cuisine. Ms. Takayama says that the *umami* in Okinawan cuisine also has much to do with longevity. It adds restraint and harmony to their food and helps reduce

salt intake - by enhancing the perception of saltiness - without sacrificing flavour. The food grown in Ogimi uses little to no pesticides, says Makoto Takahara, a young farmer. Printing to an *okura* (okra) farm, he says: "We even let weeds grow here. They are also life. They bring bugs, and bugs are necessary." Growing food is something children are taught from a young age; it forms part of the the Okinawan school curriculum. Even older

People live with a strong sense of purpose, or *ikigai* - a word many of us became familiar with through the acclaimed self-help book - while embracing a certain slowness unique to the region, starkly different from the bustling city life of Tokyo.

people take part in farming, which helps them stay active, says Kenyu Miyagi, chairman of Ogimi Mangrove Tourism Society.

Staying active But it's not just about food, says Mr. Morio, keeping the mind active is just as important. Even at 91, he plays Japanese chess every day. Incidentally, it was through the game that he met the love of his life, Etsuko Taira, who is 81. The couple has been married for so long that they no longer remember exactly how many years it has been. They first met when Mr. Morio was working at a radio-bulletin-casting company, while Ms. Etsuko worked at a souvenir shop. Her father was an avid Japanese chess player, and as Mr. Morio often played with him, he and Ms. Etsuko gradually fell in love.

Living for loved ones is another principle Okinawans value, along with their strong sense of community. Mr. Morio and Ms. Etsuko enjoy karaoke nights and long morning walks along Okinawa's white sandy shores. Mr. Etsuko quips they are almost always together, but a little time apart is healthy too. Every now and then, she enjoys spending time with her girlfriends and indulging in *yotsubi*, which, in the Okinawan dictionary, means 'cheering and laughing', a principle through which local people strengthen their bonds by sharing stories about their day-to-day lives.

Sense of purpose The residents of Ogimi are all about the spirit of *nankuru nai* - the Okinawan belief that, in the end, everything will be alright and life should not be taken too seriously. At the same time, they are guided by a strong sense of *ikigai*. Haruko Yamashiro is a big proponent of the latter. At 83, she still runs her own PR company, employing 15 people. She says her mission is to introduce Okinawa's delicious lessons to the rest of the world. Community is very important, says Ms. Haruko, adding that she generously enjoys going to the office every day. One day, she hopes to see shibusha become known across the globe.

The biggest secret of all, according to Mr. Takayama, is that all these values - these centuries-old secrets to a long and healthy life - are deeply ingrained in Okinawa's culture and way of life; they are organic. Like all things, life must come to an end, and Okinawans don't live with the goal of living a long life; they instead strive for contentment and a sense of purpose, she adds.

The secret to a long and healthy life is something many want to discover, the answer, says sociographer Mr. Morio, who has lived in the region all his life, is many things, all relatively simple. (meenakshi.s@thedailyindia.com)

What is a Blue Zone?

- Refers to a region with an unusually high concentration of people living active, healthy lives past 100 — not just old age, but old age largely free of chronic disease

The 5 recognised Blue Zones

- Okinawa, Japan
- Barbagia, Sardinia (Italy) — mountainous region home to the world's longest-lived men
- Nicoya Peninsula, Costa Rica
- Ikaria, Greece
- Loma Linda, California, USA — a Seventh-day Adventist community, the only US and faith-based Blue Zone



Common threads across all five

- Natural daily movement , built into life, not gym workouts
- A strong sense of purpose
- Routines that shed stress
- Low-stress living, regular movement, and a plant-based diet run through all of them
- Family and loved ones placed first

THANK YOU